

EMC Corporation recently released the findings of a survey that asked IT decision-makers in India for their perspective on IT's role as an enabler of business change due to the shift towards the mega trends of cloud computing, mobile computing, social media and Big Data. The impact of these mega trends has fundamentally changed the expectations of consumers and end users, who increasingly want to interact online, anytime and from anywhere, making IT strategically more important than ever before. The focus within the IT community has been on creating efficiencies and driving down costs. The EMC Forum Survey reveals that in India, IT is now viewed as a strategic enabler to grow business and connect better with customers. As per the survey, the top three areas where these trends will have an impact are in improving the customer experience (52 per cent of the respondents agreed to this), streamlining business functions and improving efficiencies (as per 39 per cent of the respondents), and managing mission-critical business operations (34 per cent of the respondents).

Organisations are increasingly moving to the cloud—76 per cent of the respondents in the survey agreed that combining public and private clouds can improve security and agility. However, barriers will need to be overcome to achieve the full potential of cloud computing. Ninety-five per cent of respondents in India report that their CXOs consider IT as a strategic lever to grow their business—now more than ever before. However, the top three business priorities when implementing new technologies in Indian organisations are—to enhance customer experiences (as per 51 per cent of the respondents), automate processes (41 per cent of the respondents), and improve sales and marketing capabilities (38 per cent of the respondents).

Seventy-seven per cent of respondents in India agree that their organisations view the increasing role of automation—such as software defined storage—as critical to business growth.

It was in this context that **Diksha P Gupta** from **Open Source For You** spoke to **Rajesh Janey, president, India and SAARC, EMC**, who revealed how SMAC (social, mobile, analytics and cloud) will change the way IT operates in the country. Excerpts:

Q The trend called SMAC is taking over the IT world. Can you please elaborate on how SMAC is affecting the new style of IT?

'New style of IT' is really not the term we would like to use. We use the term that IDC uses, which is the 'third platform'. The first platform was typically when the 'mainframe' was in the data centre and you connected terminals to it. The second platform was client-server computing, where the data centre minicomputers connected across the globe over LANs, WANs and desktops. Given the proliferation of mobile devices, the need to remain connected for 24 hours, and the fact that there are billions of applications and millions of users, a new IT infrastructure is now evolving. That's what IDC calls the third platform, and we use that terminology for technology that is always available, always on, provides access any time, anywhere, on demand, and to any kind of application.

Q So, what are the key components of this third platform, according to you?

The components are the same, including the server, storage and the network, but deployed in a different fashion. This platform is virtualised, automated and standardised, unlike the silo kind of infrastructure. Earlier, when you were implementing an HR or an ERP system, it came with a server, storage, a network, and the system was deployed for that specific application or set of applications. Now it is different. Today, a cloud becomes a pool of resources, which includes a pooled server, pooled storage and pooled network, which are in the form of software. This is a software defined data centre and you run apps, or interact with the apps on top of it. So you virtualise, automate and standardise it, and it's like everything is in a pool.

Q How are Indian enterprises reacting to SMAC?

The cloud and the hybrid cloud are being discussed a lot these days. Everyone is talking of virtualisation, moving to a private cloud, IT-as-a-service, moving to a public cloud or exploring a combination of the public and private cloud. Analytics is being adopted by a lot by banks, the telecom sector, et al. Mobility is increasing and it's now a given. Every organisation today is mobile-enabled in one way or the other. I cannot think of any organisation that does not allow email access or access to any other corporate apps on the mobile. The last component is social. Quite a few organisations are already adopting the trend called social. If I were to rank them, mobility is now hygiene, the cloud has the highest adoption, followed by analytics and social (in that order). The moment you are social, you need to have analytics. So both go hand in hand. The SMAC trend is here to stay and those who do not adopt it, might be left behind in the race.

Q But the cloud definitely comes with certain fears for CIOs. They still watch each step when they venture into the world of the cloud. Do you agree?

I think things have changed. When it all started about four